

COMPREHENSIVE DESIGN STATE REPORT - ITERATION 2

AS THE BELL TOLLS

Design-state audit, competitive benchmark, prototype-readiness review,
and solo-development priorities

Prepared from the uploaded August 27, 2026 Design Files repository. The audit reviewed 281 Markdown documents containing approximately 654,000 words, including roughly 342,000 words of dialogue and 131,000 words of character documentation.

Central finding

The game is no longer under-designed. It is now over-specified in several content areas while a smaller set of foundational player-experience questions remain unproven. The immediate goal should not be adding more breadth. It should be reconciling canonical rules, proving the minute-to-minute loop, validating the Chime mechanic, and establishing a vertical slice that demonstrates why As The Bell Tolls feels meaningfully different from other restoration-focused life sims.

Audit basis

- Full Design Files directory in Final-AsTheBellTolls-main(2).zip, including GDD, Systems, Progression, Characters, Dialogue, Events, Quests, Items, Inventions, Locations, Audio, and Code Setup.
- Existing Helper Files used as a structural and tone reference, especially the Revised Comprehensive Project Brief.
- Competitive comparisons verified against official publisher/developer/game sources current to August 27, 2026 where available.
- Scope recommendations assume a single primary developer targeting Steam first, with console ports later.

1. Executive Summary

As The Bell Tolls has moved from an ambitious life-sim concept into a deeply authored pre-production specification. Blackmere has a coherent identity, the flood and recovery themes are present across character writing and systems, restoration is connected to both world state and progression, the invention framework gives the player a profession beyond farming, and the revised Chime concept finally has the potential to become the game's signature mechanic rather than a decorative fast-forward feature.

State of the project

Design maturity is now uneven in a productive way: narrative, characters, dialogue, item catalogs, and content structure are far ahead; moment-to-moment interaction feel, systemic balancing, economy simulation, player-expression depth, and canonical rule alignment are behind. That means the next phase should be prototype-led. Additional large content batches before those prototypes would increase rework risk.

What is working especially well now

- Blackmere has a specific emotional and visual premise: a post-flood Gothic town rebuilding routine, dignity, and community rather than simply “saving the world.”
- The revised Chime framework - Advance, Preserve, Synchronize - is a much stronger thematic mechanic because it turns time into a prioritization resource rather than a cheat.
- Restoration is no longer just cosmetic. Seven states now connect rooms, buildings, crop capacity, animal capacity, inventions, services, dialogue, routines, and assessment evidence.
- The social design is unusually authored: Friendship and Connection are separate tracks, characters have daily/seasonal/weather/festival/quest dialogue, schedules, mood reactions, bond events, marriage/family rules, and individual arcs.
- The invention identity is stronger than a conventional farming skill tree. Blueprint tiers, quest inventions, and Grand Showcase inventions reinforce the player's profession and provide a credible mechanical differentiator.
- The project has much better implementation preparation than a typical design-only indie project: stable IDs, save-data ownership, initialization order, models, ScriptableObjects, event channels, controller responsibilities, and a data registry are already being documented.
- The repossession arc now avoids a hard game-over and uses a Year 3/Year 4 continuation structure, which better fits the low-pressure philosophy than failure that invalidates a long save.
- The world is densely interconnected. Locations, NPC schedules, festivals, shops, restoration, mail, quests, and dialogue increasingly refer to the same canonical places and progression states.

What must be resolved before full production

- Choose one canonical implementation for Chimes. The GDD's broad stewardship version and the current TimeManipulationSystem.md implementation are materially different designs.
- Reconcile the repossession assessment. The GDD says civic use and “living consequence” matter; RepossessionSystem.md is still dominated by a static 200-point completion checklist.
- Prototype the actual 10-15 minute day experience before tuning hundreds of content entries. Travel time, interaction friction, stamina, NPC availability, menus, restoration closures, and Chime travel-to-clock friction all depend on feel.
- Build a real economy model. EconomySystem.md is currently far thinner than the item, recipe, restoration, shop, and loan systems that depend on it.
- Validate the social progression burden. Fifteen Friendship hearts plus six Connection keys can produce meaningful depth, but it can also become a long two-meter grind unless events, new behaviors, and access changes make each tier distinct.
- Decide how much player-expression and decoration is core. Animal Crossing, Disney Dreamlight Valley, Pokémon Pokopia, Fae Farm, and current life-sim expectations put significant pressure on personalization even when ATBT is more narrative-driven.
- Freeze a solo-developer launch scope. The current content repository already exceeds the amount that should be implemented before proving the vertical slice, and 342,000 words of dialogue alone creates major QA/localization/voice-production implications.
- Create automated data validation before importing the full corpus. The current repository already contains at least one duplicate explicit data ID (item_ingredient_silk), and the number of authored IDs is large enough that manual integrity checking is no longer safe.

Readiness snapshot

Area	Current state	Gate	Assessment
Core fantasy / setting	Strongly specified	READY	Distinct; maintain consistency rather than expand.
Core daily loop	Specified on paper	PROTOTYPE	Needs feel/pacing validation.
Chime mechanic	Strong concept; inconsistent implementation	BLOCKER	Resolve canonical rules, then prototype.
Restoration	Deeply specified	PROTOTYPE	Needs experiential variety and closure/access tests.
NPCs / relationships	Extremely deep	READY WITH QA	Strength, but pacing and content coverage are risks.
Economy	Under-specified	BLOCKER	Needs pricing, income/sinks, loans, town wealth, tax model.
Farming / husbandry	Rule-defined	PROTOTYPE	Small capacity and soil cooldown need playtesting.
Inventions	Strong structural identity	PROTOTYPE	Need behavioral differentiation and showcase payoff.
Repossession arc	Strong narrative purpose; rules conflict	BLOCKER	Align assessment model with design intent.
World / locations	Strongly specified	READY	Prioritize slice locations only.
UI / input	Direction established	PROTOTYPE	Controller-first usability needs implementation proof.
Save / architecture	Good pre-production foundation	READY	Continue canonicalization and tests.
Content volume	Very high	SCOPE RISK	Stop expanding until validation pipeline exists.
Endgame / replayability	Partially specified	DECIDE LATER	Can follow vertical slice but before content lock.

2. Repository State: What Changed Since the Earlier Iteration

The clearest change from the earlier iteration is not simply that more documents exist. The design now has a recognizable hierarchy of systems and content. Many earlier “what is this system?” questions have become “is this the right version of this system, and does every file agree?” questions. That is a significant maturation point.

Current repository scale

Area	Files	Approx. words	Interpretation
Dialogue	27	~342,460	The project's largest authored area; enormous specificity and QA burden.
Characters	55	~130,792	Deep dossiers and schedules; cast identity is a major strength.
Items	41	~65,908	Broad production/economy dependencies now exist.
Systems	57	~25,019	Most core systems have dedicated rules, though depth varies sharply.
Progression	7	~24,992	Main story, unlocks, relationships, Blueprint Book, ledger.
Code Setup	11	~13,530	Architecture vocabulary is forming before implementation.
Quests	5	~13,111	Tutorial, daily, friendship, connection, achievement structures.
Locations	41	~10,179	World coverage is granular enough for NPC scheduling and restoration.
Inventions	7	~8,459	Tiered progression plus NPC and Grand Showcase inventions.
Events	21	~2,705	Main and mini festivals plus seasonal/ongoing data.
Audio	6	~1,556	Direction exists but remains much lighter than narrative content.

Important scope signal

The repository contains roughly 654,000 words of Markdown before implementation code, localization, tutorials, UI copy revisions, bug text, achievement/store copy, accessibility copy, or post-launch content. More than half of that total is dialogue. The project's scarcity is no longer ideas; it is production and validation capacity.

Areas that are substantially stronger than before

- Time manipulation has a philosophical structure and three named verbs instead of functioning only as generalized acceleration.
- The Year 3 assessment / Year 4 reassessment arc is now integrated into the main story and designed as a continuation state instead of a terminal failure.
- Restoration has seven shared states and explicit material recipes for both town buildings and Manor rooms.
- NPC progression is split between Friendship and Connection, giving social familiarity and deeper trust different purposes.
- NPC schedules and availability rules are considerably more concrete, including restoration/location availability fallbacks.
- Blueprint Book inventions are framed as the player's progression tree rather than an optional crafting catalog.
- Code Setup now covers controller domains, models, ScriptableObjects, save data, event channels, IDs, registry, dependencies, and initialization.

- Dialogue coverage has expanded across greetings, seasons, weather, daylight, gifts, quests, festivals, repossession, marriage, and bond events.

New problems created by that maturity

- Canonical drift: the GDD has evolved faster than several dedicated system documents, so lower-level files can contradict the current vision.
- Content multiplication: every additional social state, weather condition, festival, restoration stage, marriage state, and quest phase multiplies conditional content combinations.
- Progression lockstep: restoration stage is used broadly across access, capacity, services, Chimes, NPC routines, and assessment. If every system advances on the same seven-step ladder, player builds can feel less individual than the design intends.
- Implementation asymmetry: character/dialogue content is production-scale, while economy and some system rules remain prototype-scale.
- QA exposure: 9,000+ explicit ID-style entries were detectable in the corpus; at least one duplicate explicit ID already exists. Automated validation is now mandatory, not optional.
- Solo-developer content debt: every authored feature becomes a future coding, UI, save-data, test, polish, localization, and platform-certification obligation.

3. The Game's Strongest Current Design Pillars

3.1 Blackmere is a real identity, not a generic cozy wrapper

The strongest high-level asset is coherence between setting and mechanics. The flood is reflected in damaged spaces, small agricultural capacity, restoration gating, community routines, memorial events, character histories, the political abandonment/reassessment arc, and the player's grandmother's legacy. The Gothic/Eastern-European-inspired visual direction and bell/clock imagery further separate the project from bright pastoral competitors.

This matters because “restore a neglected place” is no longer unique within the genre. Stardew Valley, Disney Dreamlight Valley, Coral Island, Rune Factory: Guardians of Azuma, Pokémon Pokopia, and Story of Seasons: Grand Bazaar all contain some form of restoration, revitalization, rebuilding, or prosperity return. Blackmere therefore wins through specificity: grief that is not oppressive, recovery that changes routines, invention as civic care, and time as finite attention.

3.2 The Chime concept now has signature-mechanic potential

Advance / Preserve / Synchronize is the best design development since the first iteration. The three verbs are understandable, thematically aligned, and capable of producing different decision types. Advance answers “what needs progress now?” Preserve answers “what can I protect while I do something else?” Synchronize answers “what becomes more valuable if I coordinate it?” That is much stronger than a generic timer skip.

Design test for every Chime use

A Chime effect should change a player priority, create a tradeoff, rescue a plan, or enable a combination. If its only effect is “wait less,” it is not carrying enough of the game's identity.

3.3 Restoration is functioning as a systemic backbone

The seven-state model gives the project a common language across Manor rooms, town buildings, farming capacity, services, inventions, routines, dialogue, visual state, and assessment. This is useful both for design and implementation because content can query a stable state rather than hard-code dozens of one-off unlock flags.

The important next step is experiential differentiation. “Weathered -> Rebuilding -> Recovering -> Renewed -> Growing -> Prospering -> Flourishing” should not become six repetitions of “pay a larger recipe, wait, gain capacity.” The later stages should alter what people do in the space, what the player can host, how services combine, what events can happen, and how the location sounds and feels.

3.4 Social design is a competitive strength

The character work is substantially deeper than the minimum expected for a solo life sim. Characters have personality scaffolds, history, goals, fears, routines, relationship progression, gift profiles, contextual dialogue, and personal arcs. The separate Connection track also gives the game a way to distinguish “I know this person” from “this person trusts me with the deeper parts of their life.”

The risk is not lack of depth; it is surfacing that depth without turning two progression tracks into visible grind. Each major threshold should unlock behavior, access, invitations, routines, shared activities, or story consequences - not only more dialogue.

3.5 Invention is a better progression identity than generic skills

Replacing a conventional skill tree with a Blueprint Book fits the protagonist and gives upgrades a physical, authored presence in the world. The strongest invention design is not “+10% output.” It is an invention that changes how a task is approached, opens a new routine, creates a choice between convenience and quality, or allows two systems to interact.

3.6 The “no hard fail” philosophy is coherent

The repossession arc now supports imperfect outcomes. A poor assessment leads to another year or the Regency Tax rather than save destruction. That is more consistent with the game's theme of recovery through continuity. It also preserves long-term player attachment, which is critical in a life sim.

4. Canonical Design Conflicts That Should Be Fixed Before Prototyping

These are not cosmetic documentation inconsistencies. They can cause different prototypes to test different games, which produces misleading conclusions.

4.1 Chimes: broad stewardship versus narrow timer manipulation

Source	Current rule	Conflict
GameDesignDocument.md	Advance can affect production/restoration; Preserve can hold crops, invention tests, animal care, gathering opportunities, communal preparation; Synchronize can coordinate stations, irrigation, events, NPC work schedules, and town services.	Broad systemic signature mechanic.
TimeManipulationSystem.md	Advance reduces listed durations; Preserve resets/extends spoil duration for stored items; Synchronize sets two active duration events to the lower remaining time.	Much narrower timer-management mechanic.

Recommendation: use the GDD as the intent and rewrite the system document around a finite set of prototypeable “valid target” interfaces. Do not implement every broad example now. Prototype one excellent use per verb first: crop/invention Advance, perishability Preserve, and two-production Synchronize. Then add civic/NPC synchronization only if the mechanic proves fun and readable.

4.2 Repossession: living community versus completion checklist

Source	Current rule	Conflict
GameDesignDocument.md	Assessment is framed around structural stability, economic independence, civic function, community stability, and future readiness; restoration should include living consequence.	Qualitative/systemic town viability.
RepossessionSystem.md	200 total points: five building stages, NPCs at 8+ hearts, Grand Showcase win, collections, no loans, Blueprint Book tiers.	Checklist completion with limited living-use evidence.

Recommendation: keep a deterministic score under the hood, but score the five GDD categories explicitly. Example: Civic Function should include operating days, service availability, community events, and usage of restored buildings; Future Readiness should include invention infrastructure; Economic Independence should use rolling town/player economy metrics rather than “never took a loan.” This preserves clarity while making the assessment test the game’s actual fantasy.

4.3 “No penalties for unfinished tasks” versus hard economic/story pressure

The GDD correctly avoids daily shame and task failure. However, loans can make Bellnotes negative, the repossession assessment has deadlines, spoiled goods exist, buildings close during restoration, and midnight exhaustion can reduce next-day recovery. These are legitimate pressures. The language should be revised from “no penalties” to “no punitive daily task failure.” Otherwise the game promises a pressure-free system it does not actually intend to deliver.

4.4 Relationship terminology needs one player-facing vocabulary

The Friendship system currently uses 15 hearts and labels such as Acquaintance, Friend, Close Friend, Best Friend/Spouse, Spouse, and Soul Mate, while UI planning elsewhere has used Stranger, Acquaintance, Friendly, Friend, Trusted, and Spouse. Connection separately uses Trusted, Confidant, and Kindred. Several of these words overlap conceptually. Decide what the UI shows, what is internal only, and what players are expected to understand.

4.5 ToDoProgress.md is no longer a reliable planning source

The current ToDo file still lists “Restructure Code Setup Files” and “Update all NPC schedules and routines” at a high level even though substantial work has already occurred. This is a project-control issue: the repository needs a real decision log / milestone backlog with statuses, owners (even if always Carey), blockers, prototype dependencies, and “canonical document” links.

4.6 Data integrity already needs automation

A static scan found one duplicated explicit ID: `item_ingredient_silk` appears in both `Forageables.md` and `Byproducts.md`. One duplicate is not alarming; the important point is that the repository is now large enough that manual confidence is impossible. The Data Registry should reject duplicates at editor/import time, and CI/editor validation should report missing references, invalid enum strings, unreachable dialogue conditions, missing localization keys, and duplicate IDs.

5. Core Loop and Pacing Review

5.1 The loop is conceptually coherent

Wake -> review needs -> choose priorities -> gather/farm/craft/socialize/explore -> use Chimes selectively -> observe NPC/world state changes -> sell/resolve day -> repeat is a viable life-sim structure. It supports both routine and long-term restoration.

5.2 The day length should be tested immediately

The current time design has previously used 10 in-game minute ticks at roughly seven real seconds per tick. A 6:00 AM to midnight active day therefore works out to about 108 ticks, or roughly 12.6 real minutes before pauses, menus, cutscenes, or time-stop contexts. That is within the broad range players can accept, but Blackmere also has scheduled NPCs, travel, restoration errands, farming, crafting, fishing, relationships, quests, and clock travel. The same nominal day can feel relaxed or frantic depending on traversal and interface friction.

Prototype question

Can a player accomplish one “main intention” and two or three smaller intentions in a day without feeling they failed the day? If not, the game’s emotional promise and its scheduling systems are fighting each other.

5.3 Returning to the Manor for every Chime use may undermine the mechanic

The grandfather clock is thematically powerful as a home anchor, but repeatedly walking home to manipulate a crop, invention, or animal timer can create friction that makes players hoard Chimes. The planned portable pocket watch can solve this later, but the prototype should test whether clock travel is meaningful ritual or simply menu latency.

5.4 Midnight fainting is familiar but should be tonally justified

Passing out at midnight is legible to genre players, but the game’s language around rest and non-punitive daily completion should make the consequence predictable and mild. Consider a pre-midnight bell warning and an explicit “tired tomorrow” preview rather than surprise punishment.

5.5 Restoration closures are a high-risk friction point

Town buildings close for three days when advancing a restoration stage. Because shops and services are also part of the daily routine, repeated multi-day closures could make restoration temporarily feel like the player made the town worse. Prototype at least one shop restoration. Options include temporary stalls, reduced service outside the building, NPC relocation, or staged work that keeps critical functions available.

6. Economy, Farming, Crafting, and Resource Systems

6.1 Economy is the largest under-designed foundation

EconomySystem.md currently establishes Bellnotes, a 500-Bellnote start, purchase constraints, and negative balance behavior for loan repayment. That is not yet enough to support the quantity of prices, restoration recipes, crafting recipes, upgrades, shops, selling, loans, Grand Showcase rewards, and potential Regency Tax effects already specified elsewhere.

Before production, define at minimum

- Target income per early/mid/late game day and per season.
- Expected cost bands for seeds, ingredients, tools, recipes, clothing, restoration, and invention tiers.
- Primary money sinks by year and whether cosmetic spending competes with mandatory restoration.
- Expected loan use: convenience, catch-up mechanic, strategic leverage, or emergency relief.
- Town wealth versus player wealth: what each represents, how it changes, and what systems consume it.
- Sell-price formula, quality multipliers, shop margins, seasonal scarcity, and whether arbitrage is intentionally prevented.
- How the 35% Regency Tax interacts with negative Bellnotes, restoration progression, and essential-item affordability.
- How Chimes affect economic throughput so time manipulation does not become the obvious optimal money strategy.

6.2 Farming is deliberately smaller, which can be a strength

The Manor Garden and Orchard start with small tile counts and scale to 30 and 24 tiles respectively. That is much smaller than the field-maximization fantasy of Stardew Valley and can support ATBT's intended "care over industrial optimization" identity. The important question is whether farming remains satisfying when it is not the primary wealth engine.

The three-day soil refuel after every harvest is a distinctive constraint but a major prototype risk. It reduces crop throughput, may make short-season planning frustrating, and can make farmland feel unavailable exactly when the player wants to use it. If retained, it should be communicated as flood-damaged soil recovery and ideally become something inventions, compost, crop rotation, or restoration can meaningfully alter.

6.3 Inventions should change verbs, not only numbers

Because the Blueprint Book replaces a conventional skill tree, an invention that merely raises quality or quantity can feel like a passive perk disguised as an item. A healthy tier curve is: early inventions remove friction; mid inventions create choices/combo; late inventions change routines or unlock civic interactions; showcase inventions produce memorable public consequences.

6.4 Crafting scale must be constrained by recipe value

The project has a large fabrication catalog and several crafting-dependent restoration recipes. This creates a risk of nested crafting where the player repeatedly converts resource A into component B into assembly C only to pay a restoration recipe. Nested crafting is satisfying when intermediate parts are reusable across meaningful branches; it becomes busywork when every tier simply adds one more conversion layer.

6.5 Spoilage needs to justify Preserve

Preserve is currently attached heavily to spoilage. If spoilage is too forgiving, Preserve becomes unnecessary. If spoilage is harsh, it can make a cozy game feel like inventory maintenance. The prototype needs a spoilage model tuned specifically around creating occasional worthwhile Preserve decisions rather than constant anxiety.

7. Relationships, NPC Life, and Authored Content

7.1 The cast is a major differentiator

The repository's character documentation is one of its strongest areas. The NPCs are not only biographies; their schedules, professions, family structures, grief/recovery relationships, preferred locations, gifts, dialogue banks, and character arcs are tied back to Blackmere. This supports the intended feeling that the town exists independently of the player.

7.2 Fifteen hearts plus six keys is ambitious

The two-track model can work if the tracks represent genuinely different experiences. Friendship can measure familiarity and everyday warmth; Connection can unlock vulnerability, shared activities, character-arc progression, romance readiness, and family trust. The danger is asking the player to fill 21 visible steps per NPC while many activities award both kinds of points in similar ways.

Recommended simplification rule

Keep the underlying numerical granularity if useful for pacing, but do not make every point threshold feel like a separate required milestone. Player-visible progression should emphasize a smaller number of meaningful relationship phases with distinct events and behaviors.

7.3 Mood is readable but currently too shallow

Every NPC starts each morning as Indifferent, then weather and player interactions shift a -3 to +3 mood scale. That is easy to implement, but it risks making mood feel like a daily modifier rather than an expression of character continuity. Consider seeded mood tendencies based on yesterday, major personal events, festival outcomes, restoration disruptions, and relationship state - with strong bounds so it remains predictable.

7.4 Conditional dialogue needs coverage tooling

Approximately 342,000 words of dialogue is already an enormous authored asset for a solo project. The biggest danger is not total quantity; it is unreachable, over-prioritized, or repetitive lines. A runtime dialogue debugger should show: all eligible lines, why each line qualified, why higher-priority lines won, recent-history suppression, fallback chosen, and whether a condition combination has zero valid content.

7.5 Social play should influence routines, not only meters

The strongest competitive advantage available to ATBT is not "more dialogue than Stardew." It is a town whose routines visibly change as relationships and restoration advance. Examples include NPCs volunteering at restored locations, joining meals, helping with restoration, visiting the Manor, using inventions, changing shop hours, or introducing one another into shared scenes.

8. Restoration and Repossession as the Long-Term Spine

8.1 Seven restoration stages are workable if each stage has a purpose

Stage	Primary design job	What the player should feel
Weathered	Loss / limitation	Establish what the flood changed; visibly constrained routines.
Rebuilding	Basic access	Restore minimum function; imperfect temporary solutions.
Recovering	Reliability	Services become dependable; more NPC usage.
Renewed	Identity returns	Location regains its recognizable purpose and unlocks stronger interactions.
Growing	New possibility	Function expands beyond pre-flood survival; invention/community synergy.
Prospering	Network effects	Other locations and systems benefit; late-game efficiency/expression.
Flourishing	Living end state	Unique routines, celebrations, collaborations, and visual occupancy - not simply maximum stats.

8.2 Avoid identical upgrade cadence across every building

The same material ladder and three-day closure for every town building is production-efficient, but it risks making locations feel like skins over one upgrade template. Preserve the shared state language while varying the payoff: the library expands research; the inn hosts visitors/meals; the forge changes tools and production; the Hall of Wonder alters collections/tourism; Town Hall changes civic events; the General Store changes supply reliability.

8.3 The assessment should evaluate a living town

A point system is useful because players need predictable outcomes. The current categories should be reorganized so each score is legible and thematically meaningful. The player should be able to open the Town Progress screen in Year 2 and understand why Blackmere would currently pass or fail.

Recommended five-category assessment model

Category	Examples of measurable evidence	Why it fits
Structural Stability	Key civic buildings restored; routes/services available; Manor infrastructure functional.	Measures whether the town physically works.
Economic Independence	Rolling shop activity, player trade contribution, town reserves, sustainable production, debt condition.	Measures viability without punishing a single early loan forever.
Civic Function	Schools/library/town hall/inn/forgery usage, festivals held, services open, community requests fulfilled.	Measures actual town life, not construction percentage.
Community Stability	Relationship coverage, resident participation, family/community events, NPC retention/return.	Rewards broad community engagement without requiring max hearts.
Future Readiness	Blueprint tiers, resilience inventions, Showcase outcomes, infrastructure synergies.	Centers the protagonist's inventor identity.

8.4 The Regency Tax is a good failure consequence but needs economy testing

A 35% shop-price increase until each building reaches Prospering creates a concrete recovery objective without ending the save. But 35% is large enough to cause a death spiral if the player failed because they were already economically behind. Prototype the failure route deliberately. The tax should create a new strategy, not make recovery mathematically slower than the player can reasonably overcome.

9. Competitive Comparison - Verified Benchmarks

These comparisons use officially described features. They are not claims that ATBT should copy each title. Their purpose is to identify genre expectations, crowded design territory, and defensible differentiation.

Stardew Valley

Verified basis: Officially presents an inherited farm, farming/animals/fishing/crafting/mining, five skill areas, 30+ townspeople with schedules and relationship events, seasonal festivals, community restoration, dating/marriage/family, museum donations, and extensive customization.

Overlap with ATBT: Inherited property; town recovery; farming, fishing, crafting, mining/gathering; seasonal festivals; relationship progression; museum/collections.

Implication: ATBT's strongest separation is time stewardship + invention-led progression + a town whose recovery is tied to authored civic routines. Do not compete by simply adding more conventional farm breadth.

Official source: <https://www.stardewvalley.net/about/>

Moonlight Peaks

Verified basis: Officially frames a supernatural life sim around being a vampire: farming by moonlight, enchanted crops, mystical livestock, spells, potion brewing, shapeshifting, customization, and relationships/romance with supernatural families.

Overlap with ATBT: Gothic/supernatural-adjacent visual space; farming; potions/tonics; romance; strong thematic identity.

Implication: Moonlight Peaks demonstrates how powerful it is when fantasy identity changes basic life-sim verbs. ATBT needs Chimes and invention to be equally inseparable from daily play; Gothic presentation alone is not enough.

Official source: <https://www.moonlightpeaks.com/>

Disney Dreamlight Valley

Verified basis: Officially describes a life-sim/adventure hybrid about restoring a once-idyllic village, building relationships through quests, exploring multiple biomes/realms, gathering, gardening, fishing, mining, cooking, and extensive village/avatar customization. Current 2026 updates extend friendship beyond level 10 with Best Friends utilities.

Overlap with ATBT: Restoring a damaged community; relationship quests; resource loops; multi-area progression; player home/world customization.

Implication: ATBT cannot match a licensed live-service content pipeline. Its advantage should be deeper original-town continuity and systemic consequences. Keep customization meaningful but bounded; do not chase endless cosmetic volume.

Official source: <https://disneydreamlightvalley.com/about-game>

Story of Seasons: Grand Bazaar

Verified basis: Officially centers farming and animal care around restoring Zephyr Town's once-famous weekly bazaar. Players sell directly at a customizable stall, build buzz/profits, use windmills to create goods, glide on wind, and build relationships.

Overlap with ATBT: Town prosperity restoration; crafted goods; social community; commerce as progression; familiar pastoral routines.

Implication: This is the most important economy comparison. ATBT's passive day-end selling should not be the only memorable commerce. The Grand Showcase and civic trade should become visible social/economic moments that express the inventor fantasy.

Official source: <https://marvelousgames.com/games/story-of-seasons-grand-bazaar>

Fae Farm

Verified basis: Officially combines homestead building, farming, crafts, creatures, character customization, quests, exploration/combat, romance, and cooperative play in a magical world.

Overlap with ATBT: Farming; crafting; romance; quests; magical utility systems; home progression.

Implication: ATBT's non-combat focus is a legitimate differentiator. It should invest the saved combat scope into richer routines, social consequence, invention interactions, and restoration states rather than trying to add a combat pillar late.

Official source: <https://faefarm.com/en-us/features/>

Coral Island

Verified basis: Official developer materials describe farming, town-rank progression tied to museum/ocean/heritage systems, town attractions, relationships/hangouts, extensive NPC content, and environmental recovery. Current 1.3 adds more relationship behavior, save flexibility, and continuing Town Rank progression.

Overlap with ATBT: Town revitalization; large cast; farming; museum/collections; restoration/environmental progress; relationship events; rank-based unlocks.

Implication: Coral Island shows both the appeal and scope danger of broad completion-based restoration. ATBT should avoid making Blackmere primarily a giant checklist. Its smaller world should feel more causally responsive per restoration step.

Official source: <https://blog.stairwaygames.com/post/coral-island-1-3-update-available-now>

Animal Crossing: New Horizons

Verified basis: Nintendo describes a player-paced island life built around gardening, fishing, bug/fossil collecting, resident friendships, museum collection, crafting, home/island decoration, terrain shaping, and multiplayer visits.

Overlap with ATBT: Daily-life rhythm; collections; residents; museum; decorating; low-pressure routine.

Implication: Animal Crossing sets a high expectation for self-expression and place ownership. ATBT does not need terraforming, but players should be able to make Pendrelle Manor feel personally theirs rather than only progressively restored to a prescribed state.

Official source: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/animal-crossing-new-horizons-us-109505/>

Pokémon Pokopia

Verified basis: Official Pokémon/Nintendo descriptions present a life sim where Ditto restores a desolate world, learns Pokémon moves to change land and tend plants, builds habitats/homes, raises environment level to attract Pokémon, crafts/decorates, customizes appearance, and supports multiplayer visits/building.

Overlap with ATBT: Rebuilding a desolate world; environment-level progression; gardening; crafting/building; residents arrive as conditions improve; customization.

Implication: Pokopia makes environmental improvement immediately visible by changing who appears and what habitats support. ATBT should similarly make restoration alter occupancy, routines, visitors, trade, and social density - not only building art and menus.

Official source: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/pokemon-pokopia-switch-2/>

Rune Factory: Guardians of Azuma

Verified basis: Marvelous officially describes action-RPG combat plus farming and rebuilding whole villages: placing buildings, attracting residents, restoring gods/land, managing seasonal villages, festivals, and romance.

Overlap with ATBT: Village rebuilding; farming; resident/community growth; seasonal content; romance; restoration as progression.

Implication: Guardians of Azuma occupies the “large systemic village restoration + combat” space. ATBT should not imitate its breadth. It can differentiate through intimate scale, no combat, stronger daily routines, time stewardship, and civic invention consequences.

Official source: <https://marvelousgames.com/games/rune-factory-guardians-of-azuma>

10. Competitive Positioning Matrix

Game	Primary benchmark	Overlap	Direct threat	Design response
Stardew Valley	Farm/community breadth	High	Medium	ATBT must win on signature mechanics and civic responsiveness.
Moonlight Peaks	High-concept supernatural farming	Medium	High	Strongest thematic-hook comparison; Chimes must alter daily play.
Disney Dreamlight Valley	Licensed characters + customization + quests	Medium	Low	Do not chase content-service scale.
Story of Seasons: Grand Bazaar	Commerce-centered farm progression	High	Medium	Grand Showcase/economy need stronger visible player-facing loops.
Fae Farm	Magical farming + co-op + dungeons	Medium	Medium	Non-combat focus frees scope for social/world depth.
Coral Island	Broad town/environment restoration + cast	High	Medium	Avoid checklist restoration; favor local causal consequences.
Animal Crossing	Expression, collecting, resident routine	Medium	Low	Strengthen personal ownership of Manor/space.
Pokémon Pokopia	Build habitats to repopulate/revive world	High	Medium	Make restoration change occupancy and ecology visibly.
Rune Factory: Guardians of Azuma	Village rebuilding + combat RPG	High	Medium	Stay intimate and non-combat; do not broaden into action RPG.

The defensible market sentence

Recommended positioning

A cozy Gothic life-sim RPG about rebuilding a flood-stricken town as an inventor, using a finite pool of Chimes to Advance, Preserve, and Synchronize the routines that matter most.

That sentence contains the setting, player profession, restoration fantasy, and signature mechanic. If a major feature does not strengthen at least one of those four ideas, it should face a high bar for inclusion in the initial release.

11. What Still Needs to Be Figured Out Before Development

Not every design question must be solved before code begins. Prototype code exists precisely to answer uncertain questions. The key is to separate “must decide before building the prototype” from “prototype this to decide” and “safe to defer.”

11.1 Must decide before the next prototype

Decision	Why it cannot wait
Canonical Chime rules	Without this, the signature mechanic prototype has no stable target.
Canonical repossession categories	Needed so restoration/economy/social prototypes generate the right metrics.
Player-facing relationship vocabulary	Needed before relationship UI and save schema harden around labels.
Vertical-slice boundaries	Prevents the prototype from accidentally becoming implementation of the entire GDD.
Core economy targets	Needed to judge whether farming/crafting/restoration costs feel reasonable.
Pause/time behavior	Menus, dialogue, interiors, festivals, decorating, Chime selection, and cutscenes all depend on clock rules.
Critical service behavior during restoration	Needed before shop/building restoration creates inaccessible progression.
Data validation contract	IDs, references, enums, localization keys, and conditional dialogue need fail-fast validation.

11.2 Prototype in order to decide

Prototype question	Success test
Day pacing	12-15 minute nominal day; traversal, UI, NPC schedules, and stamina determine whether it feels calm.
Advance / Preserve / Synchronize	Does each create a distinct decision? Is the Chime cost intuitive? Do players remember to use it?
Farming soil recovery	Does three-day refuel create planning or frustration?
Building closure	Does a three-day closure make restoration exciting or inconvenient?
Relationship pacing	How many real/game days to reach a meaningful event? Does Connection feel distinct from Friendship?
Mood	Does daily mood create personality or just modifier noise?
Invention cadence	Do upgrades meaningfully change play or mostly improve numbers?
Repossession failure route	Can a player recover from tax/deficit without grind or economic spiral?
Controller-first UI	Can every frequent action be completed quickly on gamepad without cursor-like friction?
Camera/readability	Does the 3D orthographic presentation preserve interaction targeting and world readability on TV/handheld displays?

11.3 Safe to defer until after the vertical slice

- Full Year 3/4 Rupert event implementation.
- Every festival activity and every festival dialogue bank.
- Full marriage/family lifecycle.
- Late Cobalt-tier invention balancing.

- Flourishing-state art for every building.
- Every fish/crop/recipe/item in the final catalogs.
- Full museum/library collection completion logic.
- Console-specific certification work beyond architecture/input/save portability considerations.
- Future multiplayer/twin-heir design; it should not influence the initial single-player architecture except where avoiding obvious dead ends is inexpensive.

12. Recommended Vertical Slice

The slice should prove the game's identity, not its quantity. A good slice is one in-game week with enough systems to demonstrate one complete recovery cycle and one meaningful social arc.

Slice boundaries

- Pendrelle Manor: Central Room, Garden, Laboratory, Kitchen only.
- Blackmere: Town Square/Town Hall, General Store, Ironveil Forge, and one social third place such as Winding Banks Inn.
- Morvanya: one compact resource zone rather than every forest/mine region.
- NPCs: Edward + 4 residents representing different roles/personality types; only 1 romance-capable character needs bond-event depth in the slice.
- Activities: movement/interactions, small farming, gathering, one fishing implementation if already central, crafting/fabrication, one invention branch, shopping/selling, basic quests, dialogue/routines, restoration, Chimes.
- Chimes: one polished use for Advance, one for Preserve, one for Synchronize.
- Restoration: one Manor room upgrade and one town-building upgrade with visible routine/service consequences.
- One mini communal event rather than a full festival.
- One save/load flow with stable IDs and migration version 1.

What the slice must prove

- The first 30 seconds are readable: movement, camera, interaction targeting, HUD, controller prompts.
- The first 10 minutes establish Blackmere's tone without overloading exposition.
- Farming/gathering/crafting each feel responsive enough that repetition is pleasant.
- An invention produces an obvious before/after change in how the player plays.
- Using each Chime category causes a genuine priority decision rather than an automatic optimization.
- Restoring the chosen town building visibly changes NPC behavior or service usage.
- At least one NPC remembers/contextualizes a prior action in a way the player notices.
- The player can end the week with at least two plausible priorities they still want to pursue, demonstrating retention rather than checklist exhaustion.

Do not put in the slice

Children, full romance, all seasons, all festivals, full mines, dozens of animals, every restoration stage, every Blueprint tier, final art for all locations, late-game collections, Rupert's assessment, multiplayer, or complete localization. Those systems can be represented by data contracts and stub states without full production content.

13. Solo-Developer Scope Review

13.1 The main danger is implementation multiplier, not feature count alone

A feature such as “one additional NPC” is not one unit of work in this project. It can imply a dossier, model, portrait/avatar assets, schedules, navigation, dialogue conditions, gifts, quests, friendship progression, connection progression, festival dialogue, weather/season/daylight dialogue, marriage rules if eligible, save fields, testing, localization, and cross-file IDs. The same multiplier applies to a new restoration stage, festival, item category, or invention branch.

13.2 Scope that is worth protecting

- Advance / Preserve / Synchronize.
- Inventor identity and Blueprint Book progression.
- Blackmere restoration with living NPC consequences.
- A smaller cast with unusually strong routines and arcs rather than a larger shallow cast.
- The Year 3 assessment as a long-term narrative spine.
- Grand Showcase as the public culmination of invention/social/economic systems.
- Gothic post-flood setting and bell/clock motif.
- Controller-first single-player Steam experience with portable architecture for later console ports.

13.3 Scope that should be aggressively challenged

- Future multiplayer in the initial production roadmap.
- Any combat system added for genre parity.
- Every authored dialogue category for every NPC at launch if coverage tools show low encounter frequency.
- Large numbers of mechanically redundant crops, meals, drinks, fabrications, or collectibles.
- Late restoration stages that only increase counts or aesthetics without new behavior.
- Complex customization breadth that competes with core system polish; prioritize high-impact Manor personalization over massive catalogs.
- Voice acting beyond limited barks/efforts unless budget and pipeline change substantially.
- Any platform-specific feature that forces parallel certification work before the Steam build is stable.

13.4 Dialogue is already a production-scale commitment

342,000 words is comparable to a substantial RPG script and is particularly demanding because the text is highly conditional. Before writing significantly more, build import, linting, localization-key generation, recent-line suppression, coverage reports, and automated condition tests. The current writing is an asset only if players can reliably encounter the right lines.

14. Technical Pre-Production Assessment

14.1 What is on the right path

- Data IDs are being treated as persistent identity rather than display strings.
- Save data is separated into domains and initialization order is explicitly documented.
- Model and ScriptableObject categories mirror gameplay domains, which supports data-driven design.
- Event channels are explicitly planned, reducing direct coupling when used selectively.
- DataRegistry establishes a place to resolve definitions by stable ID.
- Controller domains are decomposed by gameplay area rather than a single monolithic GameManager.
- Scene, day-end, load/new-game, and progression initialization have documented ordering concerns.

14.2 What should be added before production code expands

- Automated editor validation: duplicate IDs, missing referenced IDs, invalid enum values, invalid restoration prerequisites, orphaned dialogue, impossible schedule destinations.
- PlayMode tests for save/load round trips and deterministic day transitions.
- A canonical “game clock pauses when...” matrix implemented in tests.
- A simulation harness that can advance 1,000+ in-game days without rendering to expose stuck NPC schedules, economy overflow, crop timers, restoration state bugs, and event collisions.
- Dialogue condition trace tooling and an encounter-frequency report.
- Data migration tests using fixture saves from every schema version.
- Performance budgets for NPC navigation, interaction queries, UI updates, and save serialization on Steam Deck-class hardware.
- An input abstraction test scene covering keyboard/mouse, Xbox-style, PlayStation-style, and Nintendo-style prompt families.

14.3 Architecture caution

Controller decomposition only protects the project if ownership remains clear. Avoid letting controllers become globally accessible service locators that call one another freely. Persistent state should live in domain data/models; authored definitions should live in ScriptableObjects or equivalent data assets; services should perform cross-cutting work; event channels should broadcast state changes where multiple systems care; UI should observe rather than own gameplay state.

15. UX, Accessibility, and Platform Readiness

15.1 Controller-first is the correct constraint

Because future consoles and Steam Deck are targets, every repeated action should be designed around directional navigation, context actions, shoulder-button category switching, and clear focus states. Mouse convenience can be additive, but no frequent task should depend on precision cursor placement.

15.2 The 3D orthographic camera needs an interaction-readability prototype

The chosen camera direction fits the genre and target references, but 3D orthographic scenes can hide targets behind props, create ambiguous depth, and make narrow interiors harder to navigate. The prototype should test auto-fade/occlusion, interactable outlines, target priority, doorway transitions, camera bounds, and TV-safe text size.

15.3 Accessibility should be designed into data, not added at the end

- Rebindable inputs and hold/toggle alternatives.
- Text size scaling and UI safe-area handling.
- Subtitles/captions for speech, ambient cues, and important bell/weather sounds where gameplay-relevant.
- Color-independent quality/progression indicators.
- Fishing and tonic-making assist options if timing/dexterity is required.
- Reduced camera motion and screen-shake controls.
- Clear day-end and event-deadline warnings.
- Option to reduce or disable relationship jealousy/decay-like pressure if such systems are added.
- Autosave plus manual save behavior that protects players from long-session loss.

16. Replayability and Long-Term Retention

What currently supports replayability

- Nonlinear Blueprint Book branches.
- Choice of which buildings/rooms to prioritize.
- Large social cast and romance choices.
- Optional collections and ledger completion.
- Year-spanning festivals and evolving routines.
- Conditional assessment outcomes and Regency Tax continuation state.
- Potentially different Chime allocations and daily priorities.

What is still missing for strong second-save motivation

Most current progression can eventually be completed in one long save. That supports longevity but not necessarily replay. If repeated play is a strategic goal, the game needs some durable differences between saves that are not merely “romance someone else.”

Five replay levers that fit the existing game

- Blueprint specializations that are mutually exclusive until very late or require meaningful opportunity cost.
- Different initial Manor recovery priorities that alter Year 1 routines and NPC collaboration.
- Assessment strengths: a socially strong town, economically strong town, invention-led town, or civic-service-led town can all pass through different evidence profiles.
- Grand Showcase rival paths where Lucian/Vivian responds differently to cooperation, competition, or specialization.
- Optional town policy choices unlocked through Beatrice/Rupert that adjust trade, restoration subsidies, festival investment, or conservation without creating “good/evil” routes.

These do not need to become branching-narrative explosions. The goal is to let two players describe meaningfully different Blackmeres even if both eventually flourish.

17. Priority Risk Register

Priority	Risk	Why it matters	Action
P0	Canonical Chime mismatch	Prototype tests the wrong mechanic; signature hook weakens.	Rewrite one canonical spec; build 3-verb test scene.
P0	Economy under-specified	Costs, loans, restoration, tax, shops cannot be balanced.	Create target income/sink model and simulation sheet.
P0	No proven minute-to-minute feel	Hundreds of content assets may sit on an unfun interaction loop.	Vertical slice before more content expansion.
P0	Repossession intent/rules mismatch	Main story rewards checklist behavior contrary to theme.	Rebuild score around five viability categories.
P1	Dialogue/content scale	QA/localization/repetition burden becomes unmanageable.	Validation + condition tracing + coverage metrics.
P1	Restoration lockstep	Seven stages feel repetitive across every location.	Give each stage/location a behavioral payoff.
P1	Relationship dual-track grind	Social depth feels like meters rather than intimacy.	Prototype pacing; reduce visible milestones if needed.
P1	Restoration closures	Upgrading removes useful services and feels punitive.	Prototype temporary-service solution.
P1	Farming soil cooldown	Core activity may feel artificially unavailable.	Test recovery duration and invention mitigation.
P1	Data integrity	Duplicate/missing IDs create save/content failures.	Automated registry validation and CI/editor gate.
P2	Player expression weaker than genre leaders	Home/town ownership may feel prescribed.	Bounded Manor customization and trophy/display systems.
P2	Endgame sameness	One save can exhaust all systems; low replay distinction.	Add light specialization/policy differences later.
P2	Audio underdeveloped relative to narrative	Gothic identity may rely too heavily on visuals/text.	Prototype bell, weather, ambience, seasonal soundscape early.
P3	Future multiplayer scope	Architecture and design complexity expands prematurely.	Keep out of launch roadmap.

18. Recommended Development Sequence

Phase A - Canonicalization (1-2 focused design passes)

- Freeze the GDD as the current intent document.
- Rewrite TimeManipulationSystem.md to one prototypeable canonical model.
- Rewrite RepossessionSystem.md around the five assessment dimensions.
- Create a player-facing relationship vocabulary table.
- Create an economy target sheet and identify the first-slice price/cost set.
- Replace ToDoProgress.md with a milestone/decision backlog.
- Add automated ID/reference validation before more content import.

Phase B - Graybox interaction prototype

- Player movement, camera, interaction targeting, controller prompts.
- Time system, day-end, pause rules, stamina, and one NPC schedule.
- One farming plot, one gatherable, one crafting station.
- Basic inventory/storage and shop transaction.
- Save/load from stable IDs.

Phase C - Signature mechanic prototype

- Advance on one crop/invention timer.
- Preserve on one spoil/hold state.
- Synchronize on two production timers.
- Chime daily budget, UI, feedback, and clock travel friction.
- Telemetry: when players use Chimes, what they target, and how many remain unused at day end.

Phase D - Living restoration slice

- Upgrade one Manor room and one town building.
- Change NPC route/behavior and service state after restoration.
- Use one invention to improve or alter the restored location.
- Add one relationship event that responds to the restoration.
- Add one small communal event that brings the changed space to life.

Phase E - Content pipeline proof

- Import five NPCs and representative dialogue conditions from data.
- Run automated coverage and duplicate/reference checks.
- Validate one season/week of schedules without pathing deadlocks.
- Validate save migration and long-run simulation.
- Only after this is stable begin scaling to the full cast/content set.

19. Go / No-Go Criteria for Full Production

Full production should begin when the project can answer “yes” to most of the following without relying on design intent alone.

Gate	Pass condition
Core feel	Movement, interaction, targeting, camera, and controller navigation feel reliable for repeated daily use.
Daily pacing	A normal day supports one main intention plus several smaller ones without routine panic.
Chimes	Advance, Preserve, and Synchronize are distinct, understandable, and voluntarily used.
Inventions	At least one invention changes behavior rather than only a number.
Restoration	One upgrade visibly changes service, environment, and NPC routine.
Social	One NPC arc demonstrates memory/context and feels distinct from meter grinding.
Economy	The slice has a stable income/sink loop with no obvious dominant exploit.
Save	A week can be saved/loaded repeatedly without state loss; IDs survive renames.
Data	Duplicate/missing references fail validation automatically.
Performance	Target hardware class holds frame-time and memory budgets in the representative slice.
Scope	The launch feature list is frozen enough that adding a new system requires removing or delaying another.
Retention	Test players finish the slice with self-directed goals they want to pursue next.

Production recommendation

Proceed into prototyping now, but do not proceed directly into full-content implementation. The project has enough design to test. The next valuable information will come from playable evidence, not another large expansion of documents.

20. Final Assessment

As The Bell Tolls is on a significantly stronger path than its first iteration. Its core world, character depth, restoration framework, invention identity, and revised time philosophy now form a coherent game rather than a collection of genre systems. The strongest improvement is that the project increasingly knows what it is about: not maximizing a farm, not fighting monsters, and not simply decorating a town, but deciding where limited attention can help a damaged community regain rhythm.

The remaining risks are serious but normal for this stage. They are also concentrated. The project does not need twenty more systems before development. It needs four things proven: the daily loop feels good; Chimes create meaningful decisions; restoration visibly changes living behavior; and the economy/social progression can support years of play without grind. If those four pillars work in a vertical slice, the unusually deep authored material already present becomes an advantage. If they do not, discovering that now will save months of implementation and content integration.

The competitive landscape is crowded with restoration and life-sim games, including several with larger teams, licensed characters, combat, multiplayer, or huge customization catalogs. ATBT should not try to beat them by matching feature count. Its credible path is a smaller but more causally responsive town, an inventor progression that changes everyday routines, relationships that affect how people live rather than only what they say, and a time mechanic that asks the player to choose what deserves attention.

Bottom line

The design is ready for disciplined prototyping. It is not yet ready for indiscriminate full production. Freeze the signature rules, build the vertical slice, validate the content pipeline, and let playable evidence decide what deserves the enormous authored depth that already exists.

Appendix A. Verified Comparison Sources

Game	Source	URL
Stardew Valley	Official About page	https://www.stardewvalley.net/about/
Moonlight Peaks	Official game site	https://www.moonlightpeaks.com/
Disney Dreamlight Valley	Official About the Game page	https://disneydreamlightvalley.com/about-game
Disney Dreamlight Valley	Official Best Friends 2026 feature guide	https://disneydreamlightvalley.com/news/BestFriends2026
Story of Seasons: Grand Bazaar	Marvelous official game page	https://marvelousgames.com/games/story-of-seasons-grand-bazaar
Fae Farm	Official Features page	https://faefarm.com/en-us/features/
Coral Island	Stairway Games 1.3 Update	https://blog.stairwaygames.com/post/coral-island-1-3-update-available-now
Coral Island	Stairway Games Town Rank development overview	https://blog.stairwaygames.com/post/december-2021-dev-update
Animal Crossing: New Horizons	Nintendo official product/game page	https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/animal-crossing-new-horizons-us-109505/
Pokémon Pokopia	Nintendo official game page	https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/pokemon-pokopia-switch-2/
Pokémon Pokopia	Pokémon official announcement/features	https://www.pokemon.com/us/news/pokemon-pokopia-arriving-in-2026
Rune Factory: Guardians of Azuma	Marvelous official game page	https://marvelousgames.com/games/rune-factory-guardians-of-azuma

Verification note: competitive claims in this report are limited to features described by the listed official developer/publisher/platform sources. Comparative recommendations are analytical judgments about As The Bell Tolls, not claims made by those sources.

Appendix B. Repository Evidence Used Most Heavily

Repository source	Why it matters
GameDesignDocument.md	Core concept, loop, story, assessment philosophy, time manipulation, restoration intent, UI/platform direction.
Systems/TimeManipulationSystem.md	Current concrete Chime costs and Advance/Preserve/Synchronize implementation.
Systems/RepossessionSystem.md	Current 200-point Year 3/Year 4 assessment rules and Regency Tax.
Systems/RestorationSystem.md	Seven stages, material costs, town closure timing, Manor timing.
Systems/NpcFriendshipSystem.md	15-heart progression and point awards.
Systems/NpcConnectionSystem.md	Six-key progression and milestone rules.
Systems/NpcMoodSystem.md	Daily reset and mood modifier structure.
Systems/EconomySystem.md	Current Bellnote rules and negative-balance behavior.
Systems/FarmingSystem.md	Small-plot structure, soil refuel, quality and progression behavior.
Progression/MainStoryProgression.md	Year-based narrative structure.
Progression/UnlockProgression.md	Restoration/location/character/tutorial unlock dependencies.
Code Setup/*	Controllers, IDs, registry, dependencies, event channels, models, ScriptableObject, save data, initialization.
Dialogue/* and Characters/*	Authored-content scale, conditional dialogue, routines, relationships, personalities.

Appendix C. Immediate 10-Item Action List

1. Freeze one canonical Chime specification and update both GDD/system language.
2. Rebuild the repossession score around the five viability dimensions.
3. Define economy targets for the first 30 in-game days and one full season.
4. Create the vertical-slice feature boundary and explicitly mark excluded systems.
5. Implement automated DataId duplicate/reference validation; fix item_ingredient_silk duplication.
6. Prototype one normal day using the intended time scale, travel distances, and controller UI.
7. Prototype one building restoration including service continuity and changed NPC behavior.
8. Prototype Friendship -> Connection transition for one NPC and measure time-to-event.
9. Build dialogue condition tracing before importing the full dialogue corpus.
10. Stop broad content expansion until the slice produces actionable playtest results.